

1. Intro to Claude

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Kerry Back
Rice Business

Same Claude, Many Doors

One model, many surfaces

- The same Claude runs behind a chat window, inside Excel, and in your terminal
- What changes is *where it runs* and *what it can touch*
- A Pro account (\$20/month) opens all of it

Today's map

- The three modes: **Chat, Cowork, Code**
- Claude Code in the terminal and in VS Code
- Claude for Excel, skills, connectors, and plugins

The goal is to know which door to walk through for a given job — and what each one lets Claude do on your behalf.

The Three Modes

Chat, Cowork, Code

Chat

- The familiar chatbot
- Runs Python **in the cloud**, in a sandbox
- Upload files, download results — nothing on your machine is touched

Cowork

- Agentic work on your files
- Runs in a **virtual machine** mounted on a folder you choose
- Nothing outside that folder is visible or touchable

Code

- Claude Code, **on your computer directly**
- Runs terminal commands, installs software, reaches the internet
- The folder you open is where it starts — it can work beyond it

Same Claude, three places it can run code: the cloud, a VM, or your machine. The mode decides what it can see and touch — which is a security decision as much as a convenience one.

What Each Mode Can Touch

Capability	Chat	Cowork	Code
Run code	✓ (cloud)	✓ (VM)	✓ (your machine)
Web access	✓	—	✓
Read your local files	upload only	folder only	✓
Write / edit local files	—	folder only	✓
Run terminal commands	—	—	✓
Skills, connectors	✓	✓	✓

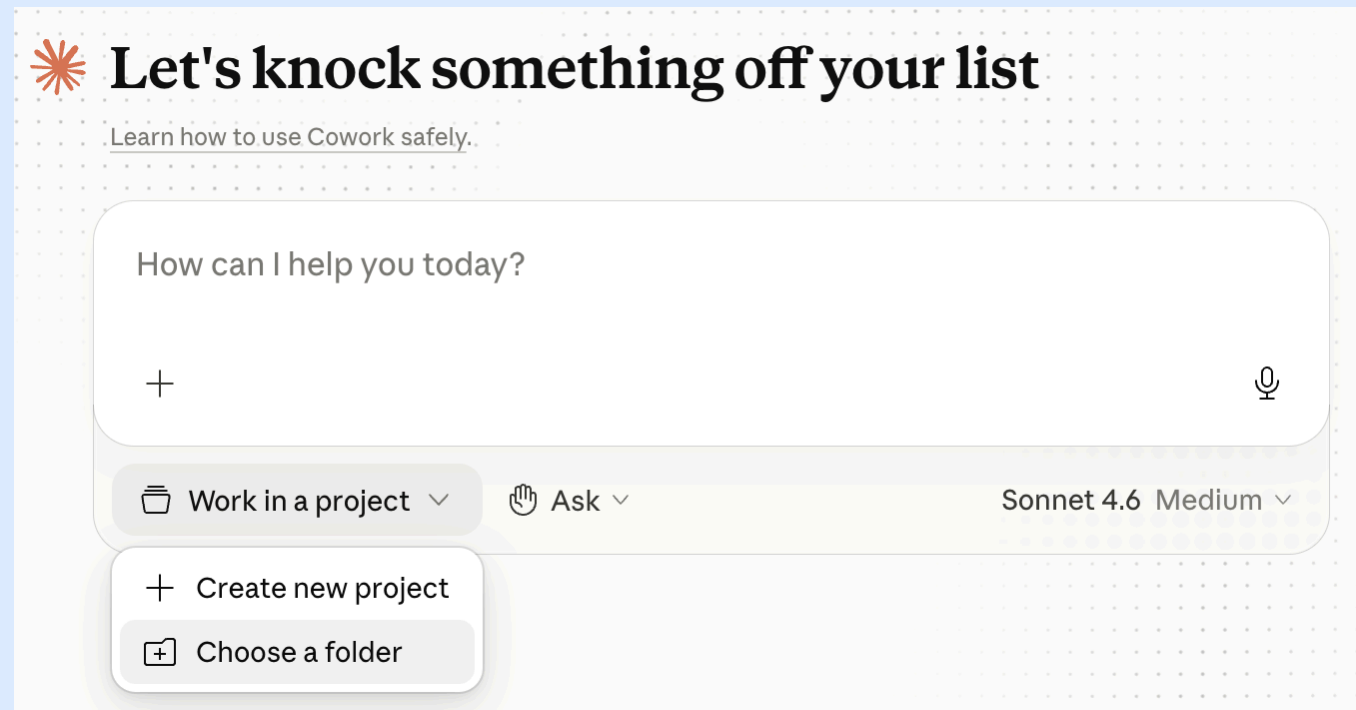
Reach grows left to right — and so does what you are trusting it with. Match the mode to the task and to the sensitivity of the data.

Opening a Folder

In Cowork and Code, you open a folder to give Claude access to your local files.

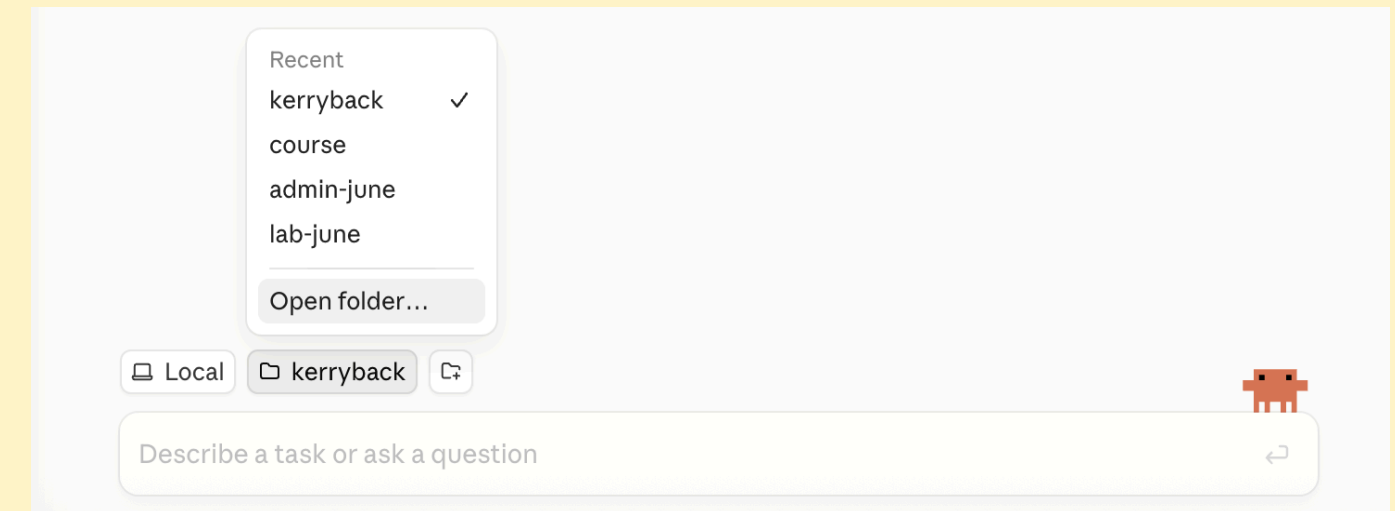
Cowork

Click *Work in a project* at the bottom of the chat, then *Choose a folder*



Code

Click the folder icon in the toolbar, or use the dropdown → *Open folder...*



Claude Code

In the Terminal and in VS Code

The `claude` command

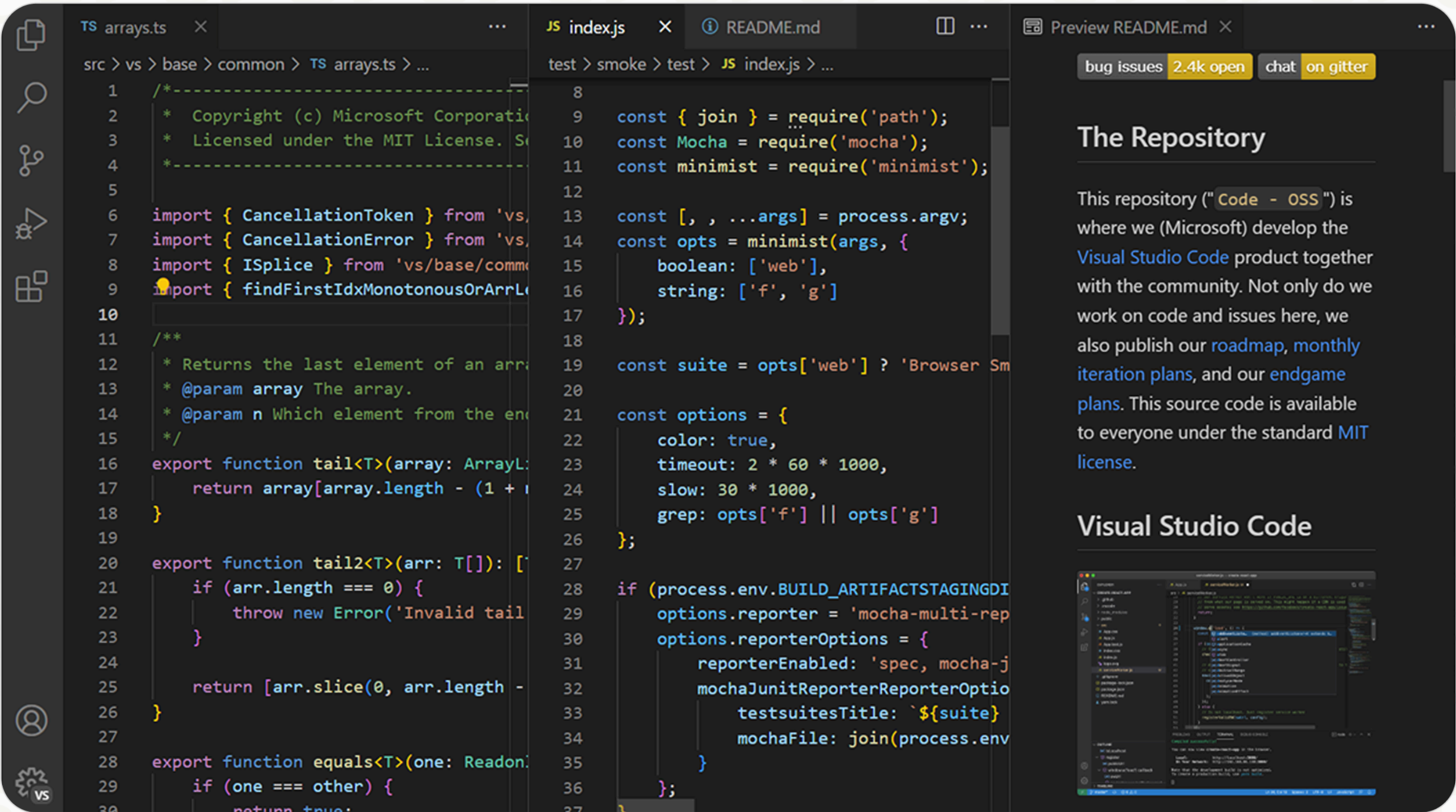
- Claude Code is also a terminal program — type `claude` and start working
- Same engine as the Code tab in Claude Desktop
- This is how developers run it, and how we deploy things

The VS Code extension

- VS Code is the standard free code editor
- The Claude extension puts Claude in a side panel, aware of your open files
- It shows proposed edits as a **diff** you approve before anything changes

For research work you will mostly live in VS Code with Claude beside you — editing scripts, running notebooks, and reviewing every change before it lands.

Claude Editing Your Code



Claude for Excel

A Chat Panel Inside Excel

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K
1	Mortgage Amortization Schedule										
2											
3	Inputs										
4	Loan Amount	\$400,000									
5	Annual Interest	6.500%									
6	Term (Years)	30									
7	Payments per	12									
8	Start Date	01/01/2026									
9											
10	Outputs										
11	Total Payment	360									
12	Periodic Rate	0.5417%									
13	Monthly Paym	\$2,528.27									
14	Total Paid	\$910,177.95									
15	Total Interest	\$510,177.95									
16											
17	Amortization Schedule										
18	Period	Date	Beginning Balance	Payment	Principal	Interest	Ending Balance	Cumulative Interest			
19	1	01/01/2026	\$400,000.00	\$2,528.27	\$361.61	\$2,166.67	\$399,638.39	\$2,166.67			
20	2	02/01/2026	\$399,638.39	\$2,528.27	\$363.56	\$2,164.71	\$399,274.83	\$4,331.37			
21	3	03/01/2026	\$399,274.83	\$2,528.27	\$365.53	\$2,162.74	\$398,909.30	\$6,494.11			
22	4	04/01/2026	\$398,909.30	\$2,528.27	\$367.51	\$2,160.76	\$398,541.78	\$8,654.87			
23	5	05/01/2026	\$398,541.78	\$2,528.27	\$369.50	\$2,158.77	\$398,172.28	\$10,813.64			
24	6	06/01/2026	\$398,172.28	\$2,528.27	\$371.51	\$2,156.77	\$397,800.77	\$12,970.41			
25	7	07/01/2026	\$397,800.77	\$2,528.27	\$373.52	\$2,154.75	\$397,427.26	\$15,125.16			
26	8	08/01/2026	\$397,427.26	\$2,528.27	\$375.54	\$2,152.73	\$397,051.71	\$17,277.89			
27	9	09/01/2026	\$397,051.71	\$2,528.27	\$377.58	\$2,150.70	\$396,674.14	\$19,428.59			
28	10	10/01/2026	\$396,674.14	\$2,528.27	\$379.62	\$2,148.65	\$396,294.52	\$21,577.24			
29	11	11/01/2026	\$396,294.52	\$2,528.27	\$381.68	\$2,146.60	\$395,912.84	\$23,723.84			

Claude

⌚ ⊕ ⋮ i

create a mortgage amortization table. assume a 30-year mortgage. allow the other parameters to be inputs.

I'll build a mortgage amortization table on Sheet1 — an inputs block (loan amount, rate, etc.) feeding a 360-month schedule for the 30-year term.

Let me set up the inputs section first.

Build inputs block in A1:B8 >

Now the calculated summary outputs:

Build outputs block in A10:B15 >

Payment of \$2,528.27/mo checks out. Now the schedule headers and the first row, then I'll fill down 360 periods.

The Claude add-in puts a chat panel directly inside Excel. You describe what you want — formulas, tables, charts, an amortization schedule — and Claude builds it in the active sheet. No Python, no terminal. Install it from the Microsoft Office Add-ins store.

Skills

Reusable, One-Command Workflows

What a skill is

- A saved procedure Claude follows for a specific kind of task
- A folder with a `SKILL.md` file — plain instructions, optional scripts
- Write “how to do X well” once; every future run follows it

Built in and shareable

- Anthropic ships skills for Excel, Word, PowerPoint, and PDF
- You can add your own or install others'
- Same skill works in Claude.ai, Claude Code, and the add-ins

A skill is codified expertise, not a smarter model — the subject of a whole session later. Here, just know the three ways they fire.

Three Ways a Skill Fires

Slash command

You type `/critique` or `/pptx` to invoke it directly

Natural language

You ask in plain English and Claude runs the matching skill

Automatic

“Create an Excel file” triggers the Excel skill on its own — Claude reads each skill’s description and picks

Because each skill carries a short description Claude always sees, it knows which ones exist and when to reach for them — without you naming them.

Connectors

Plugging Claude Into Your Systems

MCP: the universal plug

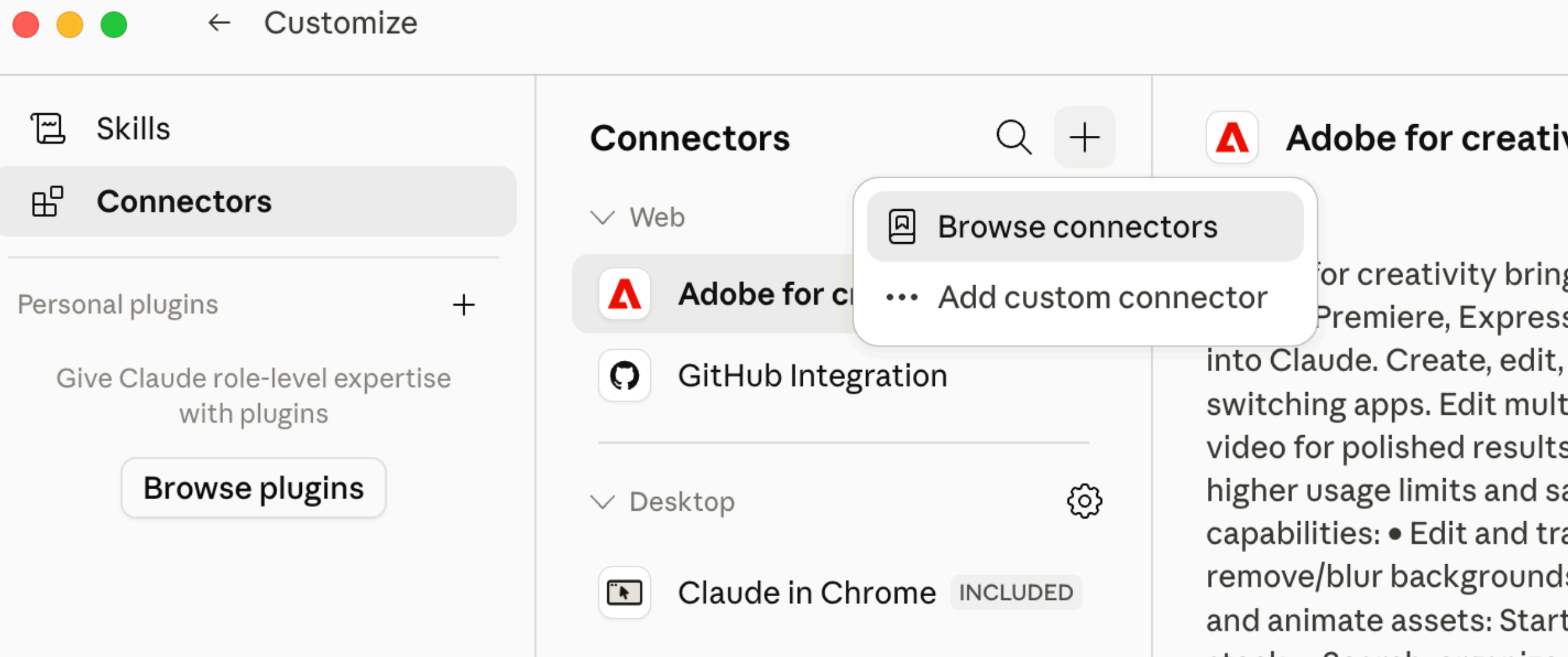
- A **connector** links Claude to an outside service — a database, your email, a document store
- The standard is MCP, the Model Context Protocol
- MCP is to AI what USB is to devices: one way to plug anything in

What it enables

- “Ask our sales database in plain English”
- “Check my calendar and draft the replies”
- Add from a directory of ready-made connectors, or point it at your own

Connectors are how AI stops being a general assistant and starts knowing *your* data — safely and centrally, rather than through copy-paste.

Adding a Connector



A connector needs a name and an address; sensitive ones authenticate the way any app does — an API key, or a corporate single sign-on. Once added, its tools are available in every chat.

Plugins

Bundling It All to Share

What a plugin is

- A single installable package that can bundle several pieces at once
- The way a team distributes a shared setup — everyone installs one thing
- `/plugin install` and you have the whole kit

What it can contain

- Skills, custom agents, connectors (MCP servers)
- Hooks and output styles that shape behavior
- Skills are for *you*; plugins are for a *team*

For your own work, a skill is enough. When a department wants everyone working the same way, a plugin ships the whole standard in one command.

Choosing a Model

Model	Best for	Cost
Haiku	Fast, simple, high-volume tasks	Lowest
Sonnet	The everyday default — fast and capable	Middle
Opus	The hardest reasoning and coding	Highest, burns quota fastest

A dropdown below the prompt lets you pick. Use Sonnet to conserve your quota; reach for Opus when a task is genuinely hard. The cheaper models are remarkably good now.

The Map

One Claude, reached through many doors: **Chat, Cowork, Code** for how much of your machine it touches; the terminal and **VS Code** for real work; **Excel** for spreadsheets; and **skills, connectors, and plugins** to give it your procedures and your data.

Breakout

Questions to Discuss

- For your own work, which mode fits best — the sandboxed Chat, the folder-bounded Cowork, or the full-access Code?
- What system at Rice would you most want a connector to — so you could just *ask* it questions?
- What is a repeatable task in your work that would make a good first skill?
- Where does the extra reach of Code mode make you cautious — and what would make you comfortable?